

Psalms 35

Plead My Cause

Fight against them that fight against me
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Plead my cause, O LORD, with them that strive with me: fight against them that fight against me.*
- 2 *Take hold of shield and buckler, and stand up for mine help.*
- 3 *Draw out also the spear, and stop the way against them that persecute me: say unto my soul, I am thy salvation.*
- 4 *Let them be confounded and put to shame that seek after my soul: let them be turned back and brought to confusion that devise my hurt.*
- 5 *Let them be as chaff before the wind: and let the angel of the LORD chase them.*
- 6 *Let their way be dark and slippery: and let the angel of the LORD persecute them.*
- 7 *For without cause have they hid for me their net in a pit, which without cause they have digged for my soul.*
- 8 *Let destruction come upon him at unawares; and let his net that he hath hid catch himself: into that very destruction let him fall.*
- 9 *And my soul shall be joyful in the LORD: it shall rejoice in his salvation.*
- 10 *All my bones shall say, LORD, who is like unto thee, which deliverest the poor from him that is too strong for him, yea, the poor and the needy from him that spoileth him?*
- 11 *False witnesses did rise up; they laid to my charge things that I knew not.*
- 12 *They rewarded me evil for good to the spoiling of my soul.*
- 13 *But as for me, when they were sick, my clothing was sackcloth: I humbled my soul with fasting; and my prayer returned into mine own bosom.*
- 14 *I behaved myself as though he had been my friend or brother: I bowed down heavily, as one that mourneth for his mother.*
- 15 *But in mine adversity they rejoiced, and gathered themselves together: yea, the objects gathered themselves together against me, and I knew it not; they did tear me, and ceased not:*
- 16 *With hypocritical mockers in feasts, they gnashed upon me with their teeth.*
- 17 *Lord, how long wilt thou look on? rescue my soul from their destructions, my darling from the lions.*
- 18 *I will give thee thanks in the great congregation: I will praise thee among much people.*
- 19 *Let not them that are mine enemies wrongfully rejoice over me: neither let them wink with the eye that hate me without a cause.*
- 20 *For they speak not peace: but they devise deceitful matters against them that are quiet in the land.*
- 21 *Yea, they opened their mouth wide against me, and said, Aha, aha, our eye hath seen it.*
- 22 *This thou hast seen, O LORD: keep not silence: O Lord, be not far from me.*
- 23 *Stir up thyself, and awake to my judgment, even unto my cause, my God and my Lord.*
- 24 *Judge me, O LORD my God, according to thy righteousness; and let them not rejoice over me.*
- 25 *Let them not say in their hearts, Ah, so would we have it: let them not say, We have swallowed him up.*
- 26 *Let them be ashamed and brought to confusion together that rejoice at mine hurt: let them be clothed with shame and dishonour that magnify themselves against me.*
- 27 *Let them shout for joy, and be glad, that favour my righteous cause: yea, let them say continually, Let the LORD be magnified, which hath pleasure in the prosperity of his servant.*
- 28 *And my tongue shall speak of thy righteousness and of thy praise all the day long.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 35 is an imprecatory lament: David asks God to contend with those who contend with him—former friends turned enemies who repay his compassion with mockery and plot against him without cause. Henry cautions that these are appeals to God’s justice as righteous Judge, not personal calls for vengeance; David hands the fight to God rather than taking it up himself. The psalm swings between raw complaint and vowed public praise, modeling honest lament that still ends looking toward thanksgiving.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

David asks the Lord Himself to plead his cause, fight his fighters, take up shield and buckler, and say to his soul, “I am thy salvation”—putting the battle explicitly in God’s hands.

Verse 4-8

He prays that those seeking his soul be confounded and driven like chaff before the wind, that the angel of the Lord chase them, and that the net hidden for him without cause come unexpectedly upon them instead.

Verse 9-10

A pivot to praise: his soul shall be joyful in the Lord and rejoice in His salvation; his very bones will declare there is none like the Lord, who delivers the poor from the one too strong for him.

Verse 11-16

False witnesses accuse him of things he knows nothing about; they repay his evil for his good. He recalls his own compassion toward them in their sickness—sackcloth and fasting—unreciprocated when he stumbled, as hypocritical mockers gnashed their teeth at him.

Verse 17-18

A repeated cry: “Lord, how long wilt thou look on?” Rescue my soul from their destructions; in return, David vows to give thanks in the great congregation and praise among many people.

Verse 19-21

He asks that wrongful enemies not rejoice over him or wink maliciously; they speak not peace but deceit, gaping and saying, “Aha, our eye hath seen it”—delighting in his trouble.

Verse 22-25

An appeal to God as eyewitness: “This thou hast seen, O Lord: keep not silence.” Stir up, awake, and judge his cause; let them not say, “We have swallowed him up.”

Verse 26-28

A final petition that those who rejoice at his hurt be put to shame together, while those who favor his righteous cause shout, “Let the Lord be magnified.” His own tongue will speak of God’s righteousness and praise Him all the day long.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

It is possible to feel deeply wronged, even by those who once loved you, and still bring the fight to God rather than escalating it yourself. Imprecatory prayer is not private revenge but a transfer of the case to the righteous Judge, trusting Him to vindicate rather than trying to force vindication.

Application for life today.

When betrayed by someone you once helped, resist the urge to quietly keep score—bring the specifics honestly to God as David does. Notice the discipline of verses 9–10 and 27–28: even mid-complaint, David rehearses praise he intends to give when vindicated. Ask whether you are trying to be your own “shield and buckler” (v. 2) instead of letting God fight for you.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Is there a relationship where someone has “rewarded evil for good” (v. 12) that you need to hand over to God rather than manage yourself?

2. How does praying “plead my cause” differ from plotting your own vindication—and which are you more prone to do?

3. What specific praise could you vow now (like vv. 9–10, 28) even before your situation resolves?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).